



NETHERLANDS

Capital cities: Amsterdam, The Hague

Area: 16,033 sq miles (41,526 sq km)

Population: 15,800,000

Official language: Dutch

Major religions: Christian 63%, Muslim 3%, other 34%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Euro

Adult literacy rate: 97%

Life expectancy: 78 years

People per doctor: 303

Televisions: 543 per 1,000 people

Tulips were first brought to the Netherlands from Turkey in the 1630s, as much for their edible bulbs as for their flowers.



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THIS SMALL, DENSELY POPULATED country is also referred to as Holland, the name of two of its provinces. In the 16th and 17th centuries, Dutch merchants and sailors traveled far and wide, trading in gold and spices. The empire they established stretched from Southeast Asia to the Caribbean. Trade is still of great importance to the Netherlands today, since several large international companies are Dutch, and exports make up about half the country's income. The Dutch are known for their tolerance and for their liberal social attitudes.

More than half a million people in Amsterdam use bicycles to travel to school or work.



AGRICULTURE

The Dutch have developed intensive farming methods to get the most from their limited but fertile land. Among the main crops grown are potatoes, barley, and salad vegetables, such as lettuce and tomatoes. Bulbs and flowers are probably the Netherlands' most famous export, particularly tulips. Other major exports are meat and dairy products, including cheeses, such as Gouda and Edam.



AMSTERDAM

This historic city is the capital of the Netherlands and is much visited by tourists. In the 17th century, Amsterdam was a center of world trade. Merchants built the network of canals that crisscross the city and the tall, narrow houses that line the canals. Today, Amsterdam is a world center for diamond cutting and polishing.

CYCLING

The extreme flatness of the Dutch countryside makes cycling one of the easiest and most popular ways of getting around. Country areas have long-distance cycle routes, clearly posted and shown on maps. Town centers are planned for bicycles rather than cars. The lack of traffic means that more people can live in town centers, and so small, family-run shops are still thriving businesses.

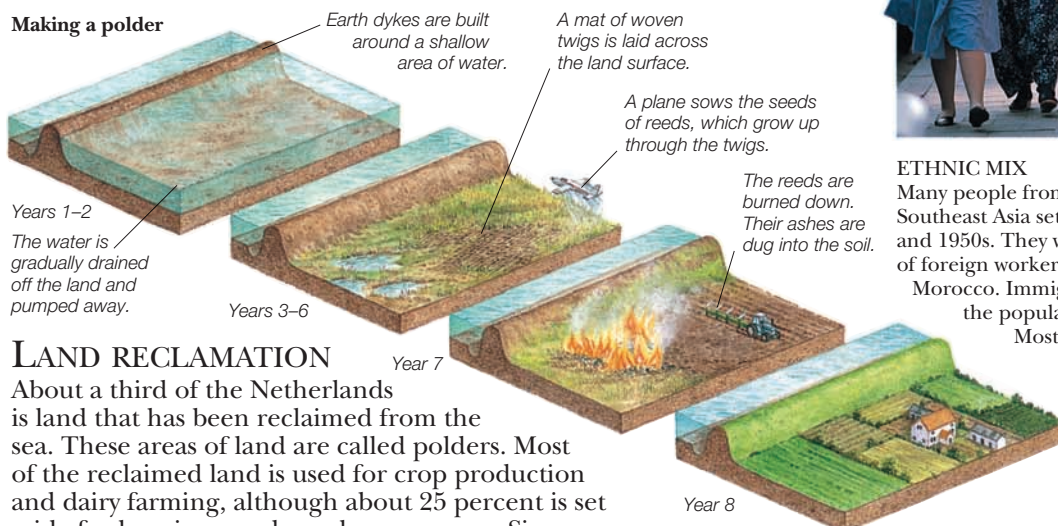


ETHNIC MIX

Many people from the former Dutch colonies in Southeast Asia settled in the Netherlands in the 1940s and 1950s. They were followed in the 1960s by a flow of foreign workers from southern Europe, Turkey, and Morocco. Immigrants now make up about a fifth of the population of the Netherlands' major cities.

Most have full Dutch citizenship. The Dutch pride themselves on their policy of welcoming immigrants and refugees.

Making a polder



LAND RECLAMATION

About a third of the Netherlands is land that has been reclaimed from the sea. These areas of land are called polders. Most of the reclaimed land is used for crop production and dairy farming, although about 25 percent is set aside for housing, roads, and open spaces. Since so much of the land lies at or below sea level, flooding is a serious problem. Huge barrier dams are built to keep the sea at bay, and water levels are monitored.

Only eight years since it was beneath the sea, the land is ready to be used for farming and for building houses and roads.

Find out more

CYCLING: 192

ETHNIC MIX: 81

POPULATION DENSITY: 80

TRADE: 280-281